

certain collapse thanks only to the $7 billion funding provided by the International Monetary Fund. Politically, the weak coalition government headed by Shehbaz Sharif is beholden to Pakistan army chief General Asim Munir, who is now the de facto supremo of the country. There is palpable discontent among the young who are disillusioned with the stalled economic growth in their country, while the army's own reputation has taken a beating after Baloch rebels hijacked the Jaffer Express and inflicted casualties on armed forces personnel.

> **"BY ATTACKING PAHALGAM, PAKISTAN HAS HIT THE VERY SOUL OF INDIA. WE WILL RESPOND WITH PUNISHMENT BEYOND THEIR IMAGINATION"**
>
> **—Narendra Modi**
> *Prime Minister of India, Apr. 24*



## The Compulsions Before India

Many experts see the Pahalgam terror attack as Munir's handiwork to divert public attention from domestic failures. Anti-Indian sentiments have only heightened in the aftermath of Operation Sindoor. Munir espouses Islamist nationalism to rally his countrymen, and envisions Pakistan as a hard state that can meet external and internal security threats with a robust military response. In keeping with the Pakistan policy of "quid-pro-quo plus military response", the general's answer to the Modi government's air strikes is a dangerous gambit that involves executing a broad spectrum of provocative strikes against India to precipitate a war and then seek international mediation.

Strategically, India had sought to maintain controllable, tactical actions such as missile or artillery strikes while avoiding broader escalation. But Pakistan's upping the ante post India's air strikes and targeting of military installations has left little room for a speedy resolution that allows both sides to demonstrate to their domestic constituencies that they have extracted their pound of flesh. In 2019, the face-off was a quick one, with India conducting air strikes on a terrorist camp in Balakot inside Pakistani territory for the first time since the 1971 war. Pakistan had retaliated the next day by sending a squadron of fighters and dropping one of its munitions close to an Indian military ammunition store, showing that it could penetrate India's airspace at will. And when Indian fighters scrambled to take them on, the Pakistani jets shot down the MiG-21 piloted by Wing Commander Abhinandan Varthaman, who ejected from the aircraft but fell in PoK and was taken prisoner. It was only after stiff negotiations and intervention by major powers that the then prime minister Imran Khan had him released. Both India and Pakistan declared victory to their respective countrymen and the showdown ended. In contrast, the current standoff has moved rapidly down the slippery slope towards all-out war.

## How We Match Up

If one were to compare the military strength of the two adversaries, India appears to have a decisive edge over Pakistan in terms of sheer number and range of firepower. India's military is one of the largest and most modern in the world. Strategic partnerships with global powers like Russia, the US, France and Israel, along with indigenous development, have also ensured that it has state-of-the-art military equipment. Its active personnel number 1.46 million, supplemented by 1.15 million reserves and 2.5 million paramilitary forces, taking the total beyond 5 million.

Pakistan, on the other hand, has 654,000 active personnel, 550,000 reserves and 500,000 paramilitary forces, its total strength adding up to 1.7 million, battle-hardened from counter-insurgency operations. Pakistan benefits from strong Chinese backing, a centralised military command and deep experience in proxy warfare. And while India's defence budget